2008 Toyota Prius (salvage title)

$3,750 · 250,000 miles · Private seller · Lancaster, CA

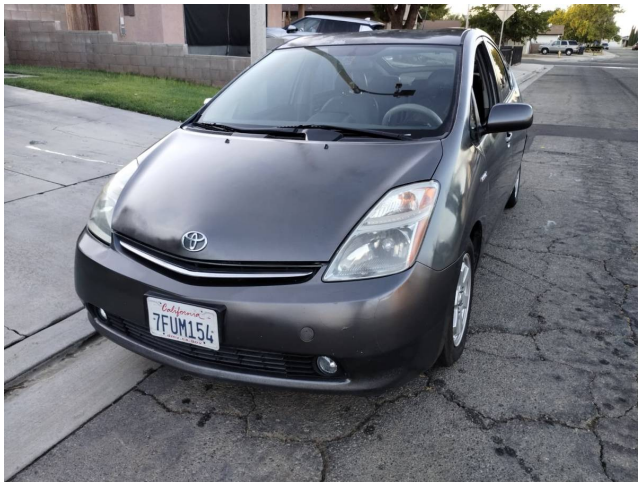
Seller: Private seller

Source: Craigslist

Listing: https://www.craigslist.org/view/d/lancaster-2008-toyota-prius-runs/ruvjeXDwtPeRp8MKsynJF3

Report generated October 30, 2026 · Ridgecrest Car Finder






+ 2 more photos in the app.

Out-the-door price	Monthly cost to own	Reliability
$4,276	**$388**	**Below average**
Set a budget in the Cost Calculator tab to compare.	loan + insurance + fuel + repairs + registration	2/5 · 4 recalls · 1,497 NHTSA complaints

Budget — buying it

Vehicle price	$3,750.00
Use tax (9.25%) — paid at DMV	$346.88
Vehicle license fee (0.65% of price)	$24.38
Registration + CHP fee	$108.00
Transportation improvement fee	$32.00
Title transfer	$15.00
Total out-the-door	$4,276.25
+ Pre-purchase inspection (you pay the shop)	$150.00

California taxes the full price — a trade-in does not reduce sales tax. DMV fees are estimates; the CA DMV fee calculator gives exact amounts.

Budget — paying for it

Down payment	$4,276.25
Amount financed	$0.00
Cash needed up front (down payment + inspection)	$4,426.25

Paid in full with your down payment — no loan needed.

Budget — owning it each month

Loan payment	$0.00
Insurance (estimate, liability)	$70.00
Fuel (1,000 mi/mo @ 46 MPG, $4.75/gal)	$103.26
Maintenance & repair reserve	$200.00
Registration renewal (÷12)	$14.53
Total per month	$387.79

Running costs without the loan: **$388/mo**. Estimated first-year cost of ownership: **$9,080** (out-the-door + inspection + 12 months of running costs + loan interest).

The repair reserve is set from the reliability rating and mileage: money to set aside, not a forecast.

Insurance

Coverage	Typical Ridgecrest range	Estimate used
Liability only (CA minimum 30/60/15)	$49–$112/mo	$70/mo
Full coverage (liability + collision + comprehensive)	$94–$243/mo	$135/mo

The budget above uses the **liability coverage** estimate ($70/mo). Get real quotes and enter one in the app to replace it.

• Vehicle class: typical car. Estimates assume an adult driver with a clean record; age, record, credit, and coverage limits change the price a lot.

• Ridgecrest is one of the cheapest places in California to insure a car (about $107–110/mo average).

• A lender will require full coverage. On an older, cheap car paid in cash, liability-only can make sense — but you'd pay for your own repairs after an at-fault accident.

• California's minimum (30/60/15) is low; $100k/$300k/$100k liability is commonly recommended.

• Ask about military/government discounts (NAWS China Lake), bundling, and low-mileage discounts.

Reliability

Rating: Below average (2/5)

Cheap gen-2 Prius in town-car range. Salvage title plus 250k miles, so only worth it after an inspection.

NHTSA data for this model year: 4 recalls · 1,497 owner complaints (152 involving a crash). Most complaints: Exterior Lighting (579), Service Brakes (395), Electrical System (235), Hydraulic (171), Vehicle Speed Control (156), Electric (77).

Known issues for this model

• Salvage title: damage unknown

• Hybrid battery age (2004–2009 packs are near end of life unless replaced)

• Brake actuator / ABS pump failure

• Dash display (combination meter) failure

• Oil burning past 200k

Check on this car before buying

• Get the VIN, run Copart/IAAI history

• See the Carfax records

• Ask for hybrid battery replacement receipts

• Hybrid battery scan

• Check for dash or brake warning lights

• Pre-purchase inspection

Notes

Added 2026-10-30 (Prius search). Posted 10/22. In the usual search area (Antelope Valley, about 1.5 hours). SALVAGE title, 250k mi. Seller says it runs excellent, cold AC, strong batteries, no check-engine light, Carfax maintenance records, registered to May. Price slightly negotiable. Seller asks for text only.

Vetting checklist (0/12 done)

- [ ] Checked KBB/Edmunds fair price
- [ ] Recalls checked / completed
- [ ] Clean title in seller's name
- [ ] Test drive incl. highway & hills
- [ ] No overheating; coolant clean
- [ ] Pre-purchase inspection
- [ ] VIN decoded & matches listing
- [ ] History report (Carfax/AutoCheck/NMVTIS)
- [ ] Valid smog cert (< 90 days)
- [ ] A/C cold after 15+ min
- [ ] Tires OK (tread, dry-rot, DOT date)
- [ ] Written out-the-door price

All costs and insurance figures are estimates for planning, not quotes. Confirm fees with the CA DMV, rates with insurers, and the car's condition with an independent pre-purchase inspection.